

Blueprint:

Workplace Edge - Conflict Isn't a Threat

Legend: **Orange- 360 Content** **Purple- Synthesia Video** **Green - Downloadable Worksheets**

1. Lesson Overview

Lesson Title: Conflict Isn't a Threat

Pathway (I, We, Us): We

Skill Focus: Navigating healthy tension and disagreement

2. Learning Objectives **Rise 360 content - list**

Learners will be able to:

- Recognize how unspoken tension affects trust, psychological safety, and decision quality
- Practise language that normalizes disagreement and invites respectful challenge
- Apply one conflict-curious phrase in a real conversation to strengthen alignment

Synthesia Welcome Video: “Welcome to this Workplace Edge lesson: *Conflict Isn't a Threat*. Today we'll look at how to name disagreement in respectful ways, ways that build alignment instead of eroding trust.

Text block:

Heading: Workplace Challenge

In many teams, disagreement is quietly avoided. Whether due to hierarchy, cultural norms, or discomfort, team members may stay silent even when they see a better way forward. This avoidance slows progress, leads to surface level alignment, and misses opportunities for stronger outcomes. When handled constructively, conflict isn't a threat, it's a sign of engagement. Teams that learn to name and navigate tension perform better, because they surface unspoken risks and align more deeply. This lesson helps learners reframe conflict as a source of progress, and build language to engage respectfully.

Text block: Bulleted List

Heading: Learning Objectives

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3. Spark (5–10 minutes)

Synthesia video

At one tech company, a missed disagreement over timeline estimates caused weeks of delays. Why? No one wanted to challenge the confident speaker on Zoom.

According to Patrick Lencioni’s model (*The Five Dysfunctions of a Team*), fear of conflict is one of the most common blockers to high team performance. McKinsey-backed studies show that teams who address conflict directly outperform those who avoid it by 27%.

One team member once said, “We all nodded on the Zoom call, but no one actually agreed.” Without space for respectful disagreement, teams can create the illusion of alignment and pay for it later.

One manager shared, “We missed a huge risk because no one wanted to be the one to speak up”. That’s the cost of avoidance and the opportunity of respectful challenge. When teams mistake silence for alignment, they risk lower-quality decisions, missed red flags, and eroded trust over time.

This challenge isn’t limited to office teams. In a hospital shift handover or a construction site briefing, miscommunication about a task, like “who’s responsible for cleanup” or “when the next check is due”, can lead to stress, errors, or blame.

Knowledge Check Block (Short Answer)

Title: Reflection:

Think back to a recent meeting or conversation where you disagreed but chose not to speak up. What held you back? What happened as a result? In your culture or past teams, how was disagreement handled? Were people encouraged to speak up or stay quiet?

Rise 360 content Now imagine if you had said:

- “I think we see this differently, can we explore that?”

- “There’s healthy tension here, what’s underneath it?”

Speaking up doesn’t have to mean being combative. It can mean being curious. Respectful challenge can deepen understanding and make space for better decisions.

Rise 360 Text Block: Current State/Behaviour: Team members avoid expressing disagreement to preserve harmony or avoid discomfort.

Desired State/Behaviour: Learners use conflict-respectful language to surface disagreement and co-create stronger alignment.

4. Shift (20-25 minutes)

Synthesia Video: “Most people want to avoid unnecessary conflict but in doing so, we often avoid necessary conversations too. Disagreement isn’t failure. It’s feedback. When voiced constructively, it can sharpen thinking, build trust, and lead to better outcomes. Let’s look at how to shift from avoidance to curiosity. Conflict respectful language allows us to name tension without fuelling it. These phrases reduce defensiveness and open space for dialogue.”

Rise 360 Text Block:

Heading: Dialogue Example

Manager: “Let’s go with the proposed timeline, we need to move fast.”

Teammate: “I think we see this differently, can we slow down for a second? There might be a risk we’re missing.”

Rise 360 Text statement block: This kind of phrasing signals respect, not resistance.

Rise 360 Scenario Block (Guided Scenario or standard Scenario)

Title: Naming the Tension

Ava: “I think we’re not quite aligned, can we pause for a second?”

Josh: “Sure, what’s missing for you?”

Ava: “I’m hearing two directions, and I’d like us to get clear before we move ahead.”

Liam: “I think this could be a sticking point. Can we dig in a little more?”

Maria: “Of course, what’s your take?”

Knowledge Check Block (multiple choice):

Title: Which Response Opens Dialogue?

-“This won’t work.”

-“I’m concerned this might create a risk, can we explore it together?”

Correct answer: Second option

Accordion Block

Title: Conflict-Respectful Language for Impact

Accordion Items:

- "We see this differently, let's explore why."
- "There's healthy tension here, what's underneath it?"
- "I think we're disagreeing, can we slow down and align?"
- "I'm okay being challenged, what's your take?"

These phrases:

- Signal safety and curiosity
- Normalize disagreement as part of collaboration
- Invite others into alignment, not argument

Text Block: Consider how these phrases sound across platforms. In a video call, tone and body language matter. In email, you might soften with "It seems like..." or add a clarifying question to stay open.

Reflection Block:

Try testing one of your new phrases with a partner or colleague. Ask them:

"How would this land if I said it to you in a stressful moment?"

"Does it sound collaborative, or might it come across passive or dismissive?"

This kind of feedback helps you learn how intentions meet impact and gives you a chance to refine the wording so it fits your voice and team.

Statement block:

Tone Tip: In written communication (like email or Slack), your message can sound firmer than intended. Try softening with phrases like "It seems like..." or "From my perspective..." to signal openness. In spoken formats, use your tone and pacing to reinforce care and curiosity.

Knowledge Check Block (Short Answer)

Title: Guided Practice:

Think of a time recently when you held back a disagreement in a conversation. Now, imagine you could rewind that moment. Choose one of the conflict curious phrases above. Say it aloud, or write a version you'd feel comfortable using.

1. Select a phrase from the list or adapt your own
2. Rehearse how you'd say it, tone matters.
3. Reflect on how this might have changed the dynamic

text block: Respectful disagreement isn't just a skill, it's a form of emotional courage. Noticing when you're silent and choosing to engage builds emotional awareness, self-management, and social connection.

Knowledge Check Block (Short Answer)

Title: Cultural Reflection:

In your culture or team, is open disagreement seen as respectful or rude? What are the unspoken rules about expressing conflict? How might this influence your choice of phrasing? How did you feel when trying to use this language out loud? How might it feel to be the only one sensing tension, but not feeling safe to name it?

5. Stretch (20 minutes)

Synthesia video: Think about a team or colleague where you've noticed recurring disagreement or misalignment that goes unspoken. What's at stake if it stays that way? What might change if you spoke up, respectfully?

Practice using conflict-respecting phrases in real workplace conversations like:

- "I think we're not quite aligned, can we slow down?"
- "This feels like a point of tension, let's unpack it."
- "I'd like to slow this down, there might be something we're overlooking."

What to Observe: (add note taking block)

- Did the other person lean in or pull back?
- Was the conversation more honest or just more awkward?
- Did the dynamic shift? Did something feel different?

Checklist Block

Did My Message...

- Sound open and curious, not defensive or demanding?
- Clearly express my concern or perspective?
- Acknowledge or invite the other person's view?
- Match the tone and expectations of the communication channel?

Downloadable Materials:

Attachment Block

Title: Tone Adjustment Tool

See below

Attachment Block

Title: Conflict Curious Micro-Journal

See below

Knowledge Check Block (Short Answer)

Title: Post-Assessment Reflection

In your next team conversation, notice when you disagree, even slightly. Jot it down and ask yourself later: “Did I speak up? If not, what might I try next time?”

After the meeting, revisit this reflection. What changed when you used a conflict curious phrase? Did the tone of the conversation shift?

Knowledge Check Block

Title: Habit Prompt

Try this for three meetings in a row and compare how it felt over time.

Wrap-Up:

Synthesia video:

“Conflict isn’t something to fear, it’s a signal. When we acknowledge it calmly and with respect, we build stronger understanding and shared outcomes.

Each time you speak up with curiosity, you make it easier for others to do the same. If speaking up feels hard or awkward, that’s okay, it means you’re stretching a skill that hasn’t always felt safe. With practice, it gets easier. Focus on progress, not perfection.”

When respectful challenge becomes part of your team culture, performance improves because clarity, trust, and better decisions follow. Over time, small moments of speaking up reshape team habits and make respect the norm, not the exception.”

Checklist Block

Title: Self-Assessment Checklist – Did My Message...

- Sound open and curious, not defensive or demanding?
- Clearly express my concern or perspective?
- Acknowledge or invite the other person’s view?
- Match the tone and expectations of the communication channel

Accordion Block Insert APA references

References (APA format)

Lencioni, P. (2002). *The five dysfunctions of a team: A leadership fable*. Jossey-Bass.
Table Group. (n.d.). *The five dysfunctions model*. Retrieved from <https://www.tablegroup.com/download/5-dysfunctions-team-model/>

Accordion Block Insert Glossary Terms

Glossary

Conflict-Respectful Language: Phrases that acknowledge disagreement in a calm, inclusive way.

Psychological Safety: The belief that you can speak up, ask questions, or share ideas without being judged or punished.

Productive Tension: Disagreement that, when acknowledged and explored, leads to better understanding or outcomes. When disagreement is explored openly, it leads to stronger shared understanding, not division.

Surface-Level Alignment: When everyone seems to agree, but deep down, they don’t. People stay quiet even if they’re unsure or uncomfortable, and this can lead to confusion or poor decisions later.

Curiosity in Conflict: A mindset that seeks to understand differences, not win arguments. Example: “Instead of shutting down an idea, I asked why it mattered to them.”

Shared Ownership: A collaborative approach to outcomes, where all voices contribute to the direction taken.

Avoidant Behaviour: A pattern of staying silent or sidestepping disagreement to keep the peace.

Rock the Boat: An idiom meaning to cause disruption or challenge the status quo, often used when someone avoids speaking up to keep things calm. Culturally neutral version: “I didn’t want to cause a stir” or “I didn’t want to create tension.”

Attachments:

To be made into Downloadable Worksheets

Tone Adjustment Tool: Say It Your Way

Purpose: Conflict respectful language is most effective when it matches your tone, audience, and communication channel. Use this tool to adjust your phrasing for clarity, warmth, and cultural context.

Suggested Phrasing Variations (by tone and format):

Purpose	Formal / Senior Audience	Peer-Friendly / Conversational	Email / Written
Raise a concern	"I'd like to surface a potential risk before we proceed."	"Something's not sitting right—can we pause?"	"Flagging a risk that might need a second look."
Signal misalignment	"I sense we may not be fully aligned—could we clarify?"	"Feels like we're not quite on the same page."	"Quick check—are we aligned on this direction?"
Invite shared reflection	"Would it be helpful to revisit our assumptions here?"	"Can we sanity-check this together?"	"Worth re-checking if our assumptions still hold?"
De-escalate tension	"Let's explore the tension here before we move forward."	"I can feel some heat—what's underneath that?"	"Naming some tension—open to thoughts on what's behind it."

Tone Self-Check Prompts:

- How would this sound if I were receiving it?
- Does it match the formality of our usual communication?
- Does it sound curious, or defensive?

Attachment 2: To be made into Downloadable Worksheets

Conflict Curious Micro-Journal

A short reflection guide to build comfort with respectful disagreement

1. Notice a Moment of Tension

Think back to a recent conversation, meeting, or message where you felt even a small sense of disagreement, misalignment, or confusion.

- What was happening?
- What did you notice, body language, tone, silence, pressure?
- Did you speak up or stay quiet? Why?

2. Rewind & Reframe

Imagine hitting “rewind” on that moment. What might a more curious, respectful response have sounded like?

- What conflict-curious phrase might have helped?
(*e.g., “I think we’re seeing this differently—can we explore that?”*)
- How would you say it in your natural tone of voice?
(*Try it aloud or record a short voice note if helpful.*)

3. Reflect on Impact

Whether you spoke up or not, consider the emotional and relational dynamics.

- What did the other person need from you in that moment, agreement, alignment, honesty?
- What helped or got in the way of being honest and respectful?
- What might you try differently next time?

4. Pattern Spotting

Look across your week. When did you avoid disagreement, and when did you lean in?

- Is there a pattern, certain people, topics, or contexts where you tend to stay quiet?
- What would help you feel more confident speaking up?

5. Optional: Try This Habit Prompt

Each day this week, jot down one small disagreement, even if you didn’t speak it aloud. Then answer:

- “What would a conflict-curious version of that sound like?”

Building awareness is the first step toward courageous collaboration.